



Editing On A Moviola

Watch Tim Amyx as he edits a movie for New Horizons Pictures on a fairly modern version of the Moviola. <http://digit.in/feb21-25>



Kubrik's Flatbed Editor

Pictures of Stanley Kubrick's flatbed editor, kept well-preserved at the Design Museum in London. <http://digit.in/feb21-26>

Post-Production Before Modern Computers

Winding back the clock on the post-production process

Rahul Chettiyar | feedback@digit.in

For generations, filmmaking has been regarded as one of those “adventurous” work fields that

seamlessly combines various creative and technological aspects to deliver the ultimate dose of entertainment. Any time you look at an older movie, it invokes a deep sense of nostalgia. Be it through the black-and-white presentation, the muffled audio, the amateur jump cuts, or simply the fact that they were recorded long before most of us were even born. If you're a young, aspiring filmmaker, you already know that the shooting process only checks out the top of the

barrel. And that, in order to make your film presentable, it has to go through the viciously draining cycle of post-production, where all the additional work such as edits and enhancements are made. Today, this process is achieved through computer-based NLEs (non-linear editing systems), or editing software that we all know and love. Growing up in an age where almost everything is being done digitally, it's always baffling to think, as to how some of those technical feats in cinema were pulled off, back in the day.

FILM EDITING

Often referred to as the “invisible art”, film editing is the process of cutting and rearranging shots of raw footage to create a new and improved form of video; or in this case, a motion picture. Long before the advent of the digital era, movies used to be shot and stored on several rolls of celluloid film stocks. The editor would then, quite literally, cut the film with scissors and piece it back together, using glue and clear tape. Technology, at the time, did not allow editors to play back, edit and review their work simultaneously. So, the only choice was to run the film through a projector, each time a new change was implemented. Clearly, this process was slow, complicated, and contributed to a tiring and cumbersome workflow. Not to mention, all of this was initially done on a rough version of the camera nega-

tives, called a “workprint”. Meaning, once the edits were finalised, the editors would have to go back to the original film strip and replicate the entire, mundane process for good. Despite its shortcomings, this was the standard protocol for a lot of editors, up until the invention of the Moviola in 1924, which introduced mechanical film editing.



Flatbed Editor



Moviola

The Moviola's involvement didn't really change the backbone of the early editing process. But, it did speed things up a bit by introducing a viewing screen, which allowed editors to do their job while actually being able to see what they were doing. Gone were the days, when editors had to sit down and closely inspect film reels for several hours, in search of the right frame. Audio syncing also became easier and precise, as lip movement, or rather any form of motion was clearly visible now. In a nutshell, an editor would line up both, the video film and the magnetic audiotape onto the Moviola, and hit play. Upon finding an anomaly, the playback is paused, and with a grease pencil, the editor